

delivery and the market got wind of it, rivals would push up the price of that stock in the market and then offer shares at the auction at a huge premium.

The AS-PS pair had a near monopoly in this market. The details of the best offers in the auction were not disclosed by the stock exchange. But I learnt from my circle of back office friends that AS-PS managed to put in the winning quotes most of the time, whenever a chunky lot of shares came up for auction. I thought over the possible reasons for this. The straightforward reason could be that they had a robust inventory of shares that allowed them to participate in the auctions more often than other brokers. The other likely reason was that AS and PS got information about rival offers from an insider, allowing them to adjust their offers accordingly.

I had dealt with AS-PS a few times on the floor, and the experience was far from agreeable if not downright unpleasant. Their smugness was annoying, and on a couple of occasions they drove hard bargains, aware that I was trying to get my clients out of a difficult situation.

Once, after having being shortchanged in a deal, I made some nasty remarks about them behind their backs. Word of it got to them somehow, but they seemed more delighted by my discomfiture than offended at my choice of words to describe them.

One day they approached me just as trading for the day ended.

‘How was the day, Lala? Made some good money for your clients?’ AS greeted me with his usual, oily smile. I found it harder to tolerate AS’s fake humility than his partner’s brusqueness.

‘Could have been better,’ I replied, knowing they were getting at something else.

‘Still sore with us for the way we got the better of you in the last deal?’ AS said, trying to rub it in.

I felt my temper rising but had to keep it in check. After all, they were powerful players.

‘You should be a bit more sporting, son, you have a long way to go and lots to learn; more importantly, you should be respectful of your seniors,’ AS went on, in as patronizing a tone as he could assume.

‘I have the highest respect for you both, in fact you both are my role models. I hope to become like you someday,’ I said with a smile, giving as good as I got.